

P1301R2

[[nodiscard("should have a reason")]]

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Audience:

EWG, CWG

Project:

ISO/IEC JTC1/SC22/WG21 14882: Programming Language — C++

Latest:

https://the-phd.github.io/vendor/future_cxx/papers/d1301.html

Reply To:

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Abstract

This paper proposes allowing an explanatory string token for use with the `nodiscard` attribute.

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§ 1. Revision History

§ 1.1. Revision 2 - January 21st, 2019

- Wording is now relative to [\[n4778\]](#), the latest C++ Standard working draft.
- Add `[#feedback]` from reflector discussion.

§ 1.2. Revision 1 - November 7th, 2018

— Add Tony Table and fix the example in the Tony Table.

§ 1.3. Revision 0 - October 7th, 2018

— Initial release.

§ 2. Feedback

After a brief discussion with no negative feedback on November in San Diego, the chair forwarded this to EWG with the caveat that this paper should ask both LWG and LEWG representatives to chime in. A message was sent out on the reflector [with 50+ responses indicating strong support](#) (90%+ positive affirmation) for having this feature.

The question of whether or not the standard should mandate the text that goes in a `[[nodiscard]]` or `[[deprecated]]` attribute. There was extremely strong push back to that idea, and this paper does not propose the text. This paper encourages implementers to apply any text they see fit, and to bring a paper over on what should not only be marked `nodiscard`, but any standardized text for the attribute warning they see fit.

This paper simply proposes making it possible to have the reason present.

§ 3. Motivation

Currently	
<pre>struct data_holder { private: std::unique_ptr<char[], data_deleter> ptr; std::vector<int> indices; // ... public: [[nodiscard]] char* release() { indices.clear(); return ptr.release(); } void clear() { indices.clear(); ptr.reset(nullptr); } [[nodiscard]] bool empty() const { return ptr != nullptr && !indices.empty(); } }; int main () { data_holder dh = /* ... */; // serious error, // do not (void) this dh.release(); // just as noisy as release(), // but a little less serious dh.empty(); return 0; }</pre>	<pre>struct data_holder { private: std::unique_ptr<char[], data_deleter> ptr; std::vector<int> indices; // ... public: [[nodiscard("Possible memory leak")]] char* release() { return ptr.release(); } void clear() { indices.clear(); ptr.reset(nullptr); } [[nodiscard("Did you forget to clear the indices?")]] bool empty() const { return ptr != nullptr && !indices.empty(); } }; int main () { data_holder dh = /* ... */; // serious error, with reason dh.release(); // less serious, with reason dh.empty(); return 0; }</pre>

The `[[nodiscard]]` attribute has helped prevent a serious class of software bugs, but sometimes it is hard to communicate exactly why a function is marked as `[[nodiscard]]`.

This paper adds an addendum to allow a person to add a string attribute token to let someone provide a small reasoning or reminder for why a function has been marked `[[nodiscard("Please do not leak this memory!")]]`.

§ 4. Design Considerations

This paper is an enhancement of a preexisting feature to help programmers provide clarity with their code. Anything that makes the implementation warn or error should also provide some reasoning or perhaps point users to a knowledge base or similar to have any questions they have about the reason for the `nodiscard` attribute answered.

The design is very simple and follows the lead of the `deprecated` attribute. We propose allowing a string literal to be passed as an attribute argument clause, allowing for `[[nodiscard("You must use the returned token with api::foobar")]]`. The key here is that there are some `nodiscard` attributes that have different kinds of "severity" versus others. That is, the cost of discarding `vector::empty`'s return value is probably of slightly less concern than `unique_ptr::release`: one might manifest as a possible bug, the other is a downright memory leak.

Adding a reason to `nodiscard` allows implementers of the standard library, library developers, and application writers to benefit from a more clear and concise error beyond "Please do not discard this return value". This makes it easier for developers to understand the intent of the code they are using.

§ 5. Wording

All wording is relative to [\[n4778\]](#).

§ 5.1. Intent

The intent of the wording is to let a programmer specify a string literal that the compiler can use in their warning / error display for, e.g. `[[nodiscard("Please check the status variable")]]`.

§ 5.2. Feature Test Macro

`nodiscard` already has an attribute value in Table 15. If this proposal is accepted, then per the standard's reasoning the value of `nodiscard` should be increased to some greater value (such as `201811L`).

§ 5.3. Proposed Wording

Modify §14.1 `[cpp.cond]`'s Table 15:

Attribute	Value
<code>nodiscard</code>	<code>201603L</code> <code>201902L</code>

Append the following to §9.11.9 Nodiscard attribute `[dcl.attrnodiscard]`'s clause 1:

¹ The *attribute-token* `nodiscard` may be applied to the declarator-id in a function declaration or to the declaration of a class or enumeration. It shall appear at most once in each attribute-list and no *attribute argument-clause* shall be present.

An attribute-argument-clause may be present and, if present, it shall have the form:

(string-literal)

[Note: The string-literal in the attribute-argument-clause could be used to explain the rationale for why the entity must not be discarded. — end note]

§ References

§ Informative References

[N4778]

ISO/IEC JTC1/SC22/WG21 - The C++ Standards Committee; Richard Smith. [N4778 - Working Draft, Standard for Programming Language C++](http://www.open-std.org/jtc1/sc22/wg21/docs/papers/2018/n4778.pdf). November 26th, 2018. URL: <http://www.open-std.org/jtc1/sc22/wg21/docs/papers/2018/n4778.pdf>